

Selvedge

The rigid edge woven into each side of a length of fabric to prevent the fabric from fraying or unravelling. It occurs when the weft thread turns at the edge of the warp threads to start the next row.

Set or setting

The way the blocks that make up a quilt top are arranged. Blocks may be straight set (stitched together edge to edge, with each block oriented the same way), or set "on point" (turned on the diagonal so that they appear as diamonds rather than squares). Pieced and appliqué blocks may be alternated with plain "spacer" blocks, or blocks may be rotated to create secondary patterns.

Setting in

In patchwork, sewing one shape or patch into an acute angle formed when two other shapes have been joined together.

Sewing gauge

Measuring tool with an adjustable slider for checking small measurements, such as hem depths and seam allowance.

Slip stitch

A hidden stitch used mainly in appliqué work.

Stab stitch

An alternative hand quilting stitch used particularly on thicker fabric layers. The needle is taken up then down to make individual stitches.

Stitch in the ditch

A line of straight stitches sewn on the right side of the work, in the ditch created by a seam. Used as a form of hidden quilting.

Straight grain

The parallel threads of a woven fabric running at 90 degrees to either the lengthways (warp) or crossways (weft) direction of the weave.

Straight stitch

Plain machine stitch, used for most applications. The length of the stitch can be altered to suit the fabric.

String piecing

In patchwork, similar to strip piecing, but the strips can be of uneven width.

Strip piecing

A patchwork technique in which long strips of fabric are sewn together and then cut apart before being reassembled in a different sequence. The method is used to create many popular blocks, including log cabin and Seminole patchwork.

Tacking

A temporary stitch used to hold pieces of fabric together or for transferring pattern markings to fabric. It can be worked by hand or machine and can be a straight line or individual doubled stitches.

Tailor's chalk

Square- or triangular-shaped pieces of chalk used to mark fabric. Available in a variety of colours, tailor's chalk can be removed easily by brushing.

Tension

The tautness of the stitching in a seam.

Thimble

A metal or plastic cap that fits over the top of a finger to protect it when hand sewing.

Throat

The space on a sewing machine underneath the arm. Standard sewing machines have a throat space of less than 30cm (12in). When working on many quilts the project will have to be rolled or folded so that it fits within the throat, neatly out of the way of the needle.

Topstitch

Machine straight stitching worked on the right side of an item, close to the finished edge, for decorative effect. Sometimes stitched in a contrasting colour.

Topstitched seam

A seam finished with a row of topstitching for decorative effect on soft furnishings and garments.

Tying

A utilitarian quilting method in which thread, string, cord, etc., is stitched through the layers and tied in a secure knot.

Wadding

Also called batting, this is a layer of filling made from polyester, cotton, wool, or even silk and used to provide warmth and give body to a quilt. Wadding is available in many different lofts, or thicknesses.

Warp

The vertical threads of a woven fabric, also known as the lengthways grain.

Weft

The horizontal threads of a woven fabric, also known as the crossways grain.

Wrong side

The reverse of a piece of fabric, the side that will normally be hidden from view when the piece is made up.

Yo-yo

A type of patchwork made from a round piece of fabric that has been gathered. Usually, many yo-yos are joined together, but they can also be individually applied within larger patchwork pieces to add decoration.

Zigzag stitch

A machine stitch used to neaten and secure seam edges and for decorative purposes. The width and length of the zigzag can be altered.

Zip foot

Narrow machine foot with a single toe that can be positioned on either side of the needle.